



The signing of a peace agreement by the Senegalese government and Casamance separatist rebels at the end of 2004 officially ended West Africa's longest-running civil war, paving the way for the return of tens of thousands of IDPs. Due to the fact that the southern province of Casamance is virtually cut off from the rest of the country by the Gambia, most people fleeing the 22 year conflict sought refuge there and in Guinea-Bissau. While information on both numbers and the humanitarian needs of IDPs in the Casamance context has been scarce, it is estimated that some 64,000 people were internally displaced, several thousand killed and others injured by landmines. The December 2004 peace agreement provides for the reconstruction and de-mining of Casamance and support for the return of IDPs and refugees. Yet various obstacles continue to hamper sustainable return and reintegration, not least an abundance of landmines and periodic attacks on civilians by unknown "armed assailants". March 2006 saw a serious setback, when violent clashes between opposing factions of the separatist movement spilled over into Guinea-Bissau, resulting in the displacement of thousands of people within Guinea-Bissau itself and across the border to Senegal.

Separatist struggle behind decades of displacement

Although the separatist movement has been alive in the Casamance province since before Senegal's independence from France in 1960, the first large demonstration for provincial independence did not occur until late 1982 when the *Mouvement des forces démocratiques de Casamance* (MFDC) organised a march on the provincial capital, Ziguinchor. Violent demonstrations continued throughout the 1980s until the MFDC officially declared its armed struggle for Casamance independence in 1990. At this time, it initiated its first organised attacks on military and civilian targets in the region. In response to the separatist attacks, the Senegalese military arrested and tortured hundreds of people, as documented by Amnesty International in 1998. From that time on, rebel incursions and government counter-measures established a cycle of sporadic violence that has continued to plague the southern province.

In May 2001, another round of violence broke out in the region. The Senegalese army and MFDC forces engaged in heavy fighting, particularly in the department of Bignona. The army shelled certain parts of the southern province and burned houses in pursuit of rebel forces. This intensification of fighting came only two months after a peace agreement was signed between the newly-elected President Abdoulaye Wade of Senegal and MFDC Secretary-General Augustin Diamacoune Senghor, calling for inter alia the return of refugees and IDPs. The peace agreement was the third of its kind since the early 1990s.

Intermittent clashes between the rebels and the Senegalese military throughout 2002 and 2003 continued to uproot tens of thousands of people, but many of them for short periods of time.

The death of hard-line MFDC leader Sidi Badji in 2003 paved the way for further negotiations between the Senegalese government and Diamacoune Senghor, which led ultimately to the signing of the December 2004 peace agreement between the two sides. Detailed talks have been taking place on the practical implementation of the agreement, including the issues of disarmament, reintegration and mine clearance.

Obstacles to return

Since there has been scant data on the number or location of IDPs in Casamance – with many people staying with relatives and often on a temporary basis – there is likewise little accurate information on the spontaneous return process. Various reports indicate that less than 20,000 IDPs remained at the time

of the December 2004 peace agreement, and that thousands more have returned since then. Yet clearly returnees are facing considerable obstacles to reintegrating into their areas of origin. During the conflict school buildings, hospitals and other community infrastructures were often deliberately targeted by the fighting forces. Reconstruction and rehabilitation have barely begun. Schools are seriously overstretched even without the added burden of returnees. Some reports describe returnees suffering from trauma, particularly children.

Land mines pose a major obstacle to IDP return, with some sources reporting that up to 80 per cent of farmland has been rendered unusable in some areas of the Casamance. Since 1990, more than 1,000 people have reportedly been killed by landmines in the province. Food insecurity in Casamance is of particular concern. Roads and tracks particularly around the provincial capital Ziguinchor have been riddled with mines during the course of the conflict, with some 125 villages abandoned in the surrounding district as a result. Accurate information on the number and location of mines is also scarce. Added to this is a series of armed attacks and ambushes on civilians, including the murder of a top government official in Casamance in January 2006, believed by some to be perpetrated by members of the splintered MFDC rebel group. Indeed the refusal of MFDC hardliner Salif Sadio to recognise the peace agreement was reported to be the cause of the March 2006 inter-factional clashes, drawing in the Guinea-Bissau army, which displaced thousands of civilians in the border region of Guinea-Bissau.

Humanitarian response

In response to the fighting in Casamance, the government of Senegal provided emergency relief and resettlement assistance to some families forced to flee their homes in the region. Longer-term needs have yet to be addressed. Since the signing of the December 2004 peace agreement, the government has promised to spend about \$402 million on the reconstruction and development of Casamance, but the programme will not be implemented until a “conclusive peace” materialises, according to the UN. A mine clearance programme will be implemented with the support of UNDP, aiming to clear Casamance of mines by 2009.

In 2001, WFP identified six departments in Casamance – Bignona, Oussouye, Ziguinchor, Sedhiou, Kolda and Vellingara – as highly vulnerable and targeted them as priority intervention areas through its Programme for the Revival of Economic and Social Activities in the Casamance (PRAESC). This subsequently developed into a Protected Relief and Recovery Operation for the Casamance region, with government support, the main objectives of which include increasing the ability of the population to manage economic shocks and meet necessary food needs, and strengthening local production capacity.

The ICRC and the Senegalese Red Cross Society have provided continual assistance to civilians affected by the conflict in Casamance over the years. Since IDPs have been returning in increasing numbers to their areas of origin, the Red Cross has been focusing on water supply and health care.

Key recommendations to the government:

- Provide immediate resettlement assistance to returning populations in Casamance
- Prioritise efforts towards the reconstruction and rehabilitation of communities destroyed by the conflict, including de-mining programmes, in line with the 2004 peace agreement